he learned that Western journalists were reporting on how late the lights were burning in the Kremlin. Mikoyan told Dobrynin that the Presidium went into session in Novo-Ogarevo on the evening of October 27 and "remained there until Sunday."

Originally an estate of Grand Prince Sergei Romanov, a son of Tsar Alexander II, Novo-Ogarevo was turned into a government residence by Khrushchev's ally and later nemesis, Georgii Malenkov. The site would become world-famous when George H. W. Bush met there with Gorbachev in July 1991, and Gorbachev held court there in the dying days of the Soviet Union. It would later become the living and working quarters of Vladimir Putin, who hosted scores of foreign dignitaries, including George W. Bush, at the residence. In the fall of 1962 Novo-Ogarevo was a secluded location where Khrushchev could meet with his aides out of the public eye.[11]

As always, it was Khrushchev who opened the discussion. Present that afternoon were the key members of the ruling elite, including the second most powerful figure in the Soviet hierarchy, the Central Committee secretary Frol Kozlov; the head of the Soviet parliament, Leonid Brezhnev; Minister of Defense Malinovsky, accompanied by the secretary of the Defense Council, General Ivanov; Minister of Foreign Affairs Gromyko; chairman of the KGB, Aleksandr Shelepin; and, last but not least, the country's main expert on Cuba, Anastas Mikoyan. "From the very beginning, those taking part in the meeting were in a highly electrified state," recalled Khrushchev's aide Oleg Troianovsky decades later. "It was practically Khrushchev alone who expressed himself, while Mikoyan and Gromyko gave individual responses. The others preferred to remain silent, as if giving to understand that it was you who got us into this mess; now get yourself out of it."[12]

Khrushchev's meeting with the members of the Presidium was nothing like the meetings of ExCom. All Kennedy's advisers, with the exception of Vice President Lyndon Johnson, were his appointees, serving to some degree or other at the pleasure of the president. Khrushchev's aides had been elected by party congresses or the Central Committee plenum and had the right not only to disagree with the first secretary but also to recommend that the Central Committee remove him from office—an option that they exercised two years later, in October 1964, when they dismissed